

The story of art

From the beginning of civilization, people in different cultures have produced art in many forms. They have used paint, stone, wood, metal, clay, and even their own bodies to show religious devotion, express ideas, or simply reflect the world around them.

► **c.30,000–2500 BCE**

PREHISTORIC ART

Early humans used charcoal and rock pigments to paint animals and figures on cave walls. Some made spray handprints by blowing paint through hollow bones. They also carved figures out of stone and animal tusks.



BONE SCULPTURE OF A MAMMOTH



PREHISTORIC FIGURE

CAVE PAINTING, FRANCE



DRAWING OF A CAVE ARTIST

► **c.3000–539 BCE**

OLDEST CIVILIZATIONS

Many beautiful examples of art have been found at the Royal Cemetery of Ur, which is in modern-day Iraq. They were created by skilled sculptors and jewellery makers in Mesopotamia, one of the oldest, and longest lasting, civilizations in our distant past.



GOLD ORNAMENT

GOLD AND BEAD WREATH

◀ **c.500–1400**

MEDIEVAL AND BYZANTINE

Metal and enamel work, carvings, and embroidery were prized in medieval Europe. Manuscripts were illuminated – lit up with decorations in bright pigments and gold leaf. Earlier Byzantine Christians produced icons of figures and frescoes of religious scenes.



BYZANTINE ALTAR MOSAIC



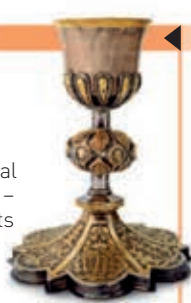
MOSAIC OF VIRGIN MARY, ISTANBUL



FRENCH TAPESTRY



ILLUMINATED MANUSCRIPT



SILVER CUP

◀ **c.324–1450**

ISLAMIC

Islamic artists decorated mosques with intricate patterns using tiles and mosaics. Modern Islam uses a similar approach – places of worship are beautifully patterned, but they never include images of people or animals.



THE GREAT MOSQUE, SPAIN



ISLAMIC BUILDING, ISRAEL

◀ **c.1 CE–PRESENT**

NATIVE AMERICAN

In Native American tribes, practical items like blankets and bags were so skilfully decorated with beads, feathers, and shells they became works of art. People also made tiny animal talismans and towering tree-trunk sculptures called totem poles carved with faces, animals, and birds. These arts continue today.



TURQUOISE ANIMALS



QUILLWORK BAG



CARVED FACE ON TOTEM POLE

► **c.1350–1600**

RENAISSANCE

Beginning in Italy, the Renaissance was a time when every form of art flourished. Artists were inspired by Ancient Greek and Roman works and produced fine paintings and sculptures that were full of grandeur, personality, and beauty. Venice became a centre for exquisite glasswork.



MONA LISA BY LEONARDO DA VINCI



PORTRAIT BY TITIAN



ITALIAN GOBLET



RENAISSANCE PENDANT



PIETA SCULPTURE BY MICHELANGELO

► **c.1600–1800**

BAROQUE AND ROCOCO

Baroque painting was all about drama. Artists painted realistic emotional scenes with intense colour and dramatic lighting. Originating in France, Rococo was a lighter style of architecture, furniture, and art that was elegant, graceful, and highly decorative.



EL GRECO PAINTING IN BAROQUE STYLE



ORGAN WITH ROCOCO DECORATION



ROCOCO FOUNTAIN

► **c.1850–1900**

REALISM AND IMPRESSIONISM

Realist painters wanted to create pictures of modern life and made ordinary working people the subject of their paintings. Impressionist artists tried to capture a moment, using delicate brushstrokes and dabs of colour to give fleeting impressions of flowers, landscapes, picnics, and parties.



RENOIR'S LUNCHEON OF THE BOATING PARTY